EVERWOOD · COUNCIL RULING

From three maps to one

Each draft scored on game theory, design practice and architecture. Then Tolkien, Le Guin and Hobb set the non-negotiables — each with a design reason and a reason the world would really be this way. Then the Musk razor.

1 · Three lenses

Lens	A · Broken Ring (Tolkien)	B · Compass Sound (Le Guin)	C · Ledger Isles (Hobb)	Takes it
Choice structure	Forced: West/East, then the North. One obvious path.	Arbitrary: three equal options and no reason to pick one.	Nudged: needs suggest an order; scaling lets you ignore it.	**C**
Co-op incentive	Party must travel together.	Best for split-up online play.	Each restored lane stocks a stall everyone uses — a shared good with no free-riders.	**C (B for splits)**
Motivation a 9-year-old reads	A lore gate.	"Restore the balance."	"The smith has no iron."	**C**
Foreshadowing	Crown, plus the far North.	Crown in view from four equal quays.	Crown, plus dark lanes you can see.	**B**
Endgame reuse	Ebb + three Root-Way tunnels.	Ebb on the outer coasts.	Ebb + Old Quay market — reuses Zone 1.	**C**
Internal logic	Strongest geology.	Perfect symmetry is the least natural shape.	Strongest economy.	**A + C**
Load seams (fewer = better)	11	12	6	**C**
Tuning load	Low: hard level bands.	High: every isle tuned across Lv 6–14.	Medium: overlapping bands.	**C**

Verdict: the spine comes from C, the geology from A, and the sightlines and inner/outer shore rule from B.

2 · What the council will not give up

Each item passed only if it earns its place twice: once as game design, once as a world that would really be this way.

1 **A drowned caldera with one breach.** Tolkien; all agree.
Design: a ring of isles reads as one world and frames the endgame in its middle. **Logic:** a collapsed volcano flooded by the sea is ring-shaped and broken where the sea got in (Santorini is the real-world model). The breach, in the north-west, explains the cold current, the gales and why the sea level can change.

2 **The Crown as a dome in the middle, seen from every quay.** Le Guin.
Design: the endgame is a promise visible from minute one. **Logic:** calderas often push up a new dome in the centre; its warm springs are why a World-Tree grows there and nowhere else.

3 **Biomes from rock and exposure, not latitude.** Tolkien + Hobb.
Design: four distinct biomes from one rule set. **Logic:** isles a few km apart share one climate. So Iron-Ness is hydrothermal ironstone; Rime-Firth is the high rim facing the breach (cold from altitude and breach fog); Barrow-Eyot is a sunken stretch of rim gone to fen; Oakshire is the lee shore on volcanic ash-loam, the richest farm soil there is.

4 **Trade lanes that break at Lv 6.** Hobb.
Design: the clearest in-world reason to leave home. **Logic:** Oakshire grows food but can't make iron, fuel or lamp-light; the friction isles can't feed themselves.

5 **Oakshire is the hub every lane runs through.** Hobb; Le Guin conceded.
Design: you come home between isles, sell, and see the town change. **Logic:** everyone needs the larder, so every ferry sails from Hearthstead. There is no Iron–Barrow lane: rival guilds, and nothing to trade.

6 **Sheltered inner shores, wild outer shores.** Le Guin.
Design: one level-design rule for every isle — towns, quests and quays face the Sound; elites and raid gates face the Open Sea. **Logic:** people build harbours in the lee.

7 **One beacon per friction isle: one flag, three effects.** All three.
Design: lighting it reopens the lane (a new stall at home), calms that isle's current around the Crown, and earns its Sign. Three beacons open the Crown landing. **Logic:** a lighthouse is what makes a sea lane usable, and the currents are the same streams the lanes ride.

8 **The Ebb ends the Long Flood; it does not drain the sea.** Tolkien + Hobb.
Design: one variable powers the whole endgame return. **Logic:** the blighted Star-Tide has held the sea 6 m above normal for a generation; grandparents still remember the Old Quay market. The Harmonic Bell ends it and the sea goes back to where it used to be.

9 **Old-tongue names that describe the land.** Tolkien.

3 · The Musk razor

Delete every part you can. If you are not adding back about 10%, you did not delete enough.

Deleted

- **Root-Ways** (A): three tunnel maps for fast travel a skiff bell can do.
- **4 viaducts** (A) and **4 tethers** (B): one Crown landing.
- **Hard "North last" gate** (A): overlapping level bands.
- **4-bell Chime Ring** (B), **storm causeways** (B), **ore ferry and cod run** (C): three spokes from Oakshire only.
- **Naming Stones** (B): the Sign is earned at the beacon.
- **Equal Lv 6–14 bands** (B): 6–10 / 8–12 / 10–14 with a scaling floor.
- **Three-tier markets** (C): one stall per lane.
- **Wrecker's Skerry, Elder Fault** (A/C): a line of lore, not a map feature.

Kept

The nine non-negotiables; 5 island grids; 3 sealed raids plus the True Raid; one Ebb flag.

Added back (the 10%)

- **Old Quay market, bared at the Ebb.** Without it Oakshire is dead real estate in the endgame. One small area that reuses the stalls.
- **One landmark silhouette per isle, all visible from North Quay** — windmill, forge stacks, snow peak, bell-tower, World-Tree. A few impostor meshes buy the strongest promise on the map.

II → 4 load seams	4 world-state booleans
I seam scene, two skins	0 extra map files